

GOVERNMENT HACK · TROOPTOTEACHER TECHNOLOGIES

Foundations of Constitutional Government

United States Government & Civics (GC) · Unit 7 · GC.28–GC.30

“How does Tennessee govern itself at the state and local levels — and how do you take part?”

Grades 9–12 · Suggested 12–14 days · Supplemental under TCA § 49-6-2202(a)(3)

Essential Question: How does Tennessee govern itself at the state and local levels — and how do you take part?

GC.28

Tennessee's Three Branches

GC.29

Local Government in Tennessee

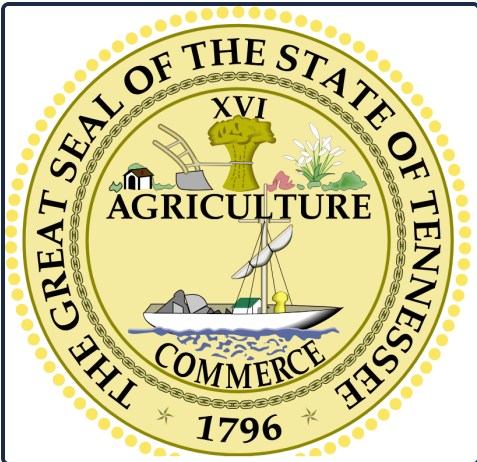
GC.30

Identify Your Current Officials

Tennessee's Three Branches

Learning target: I can identify the functions of the departments and agencies of Tennessee's executive, legislative, and judicial branches.

PRIMARY SOURCE



The Great Seal of the State of Tennessee (statehood 1796) — the emblem of the state government whose three branches this standard examines.

“The powers of the Government shall be divided into three distinct departments: Legislative, Executive, and Judicial.”

— Constitution of Tennessee, Tennessee Constitution, Article II, Section 1 (1870)

The Great Seal of the State of Tennessee · State of Tennessee (1802 design) · Wikimedia Commons

KEY VOCABULARY

Grand Divisions /grand dih-VIZH-unz/

Grandes Divisiones

The three legal regions of Tennessee — East, Middle, and West — recognized in state law and marked by the three stars on the state flag; the state balances offices and representation across all three.

CHECK FOR UNDERSTANDING • DOK 2

In Tennessee's trial-court system, which court is a court of equity, presided over by a Chancellor?

- A Criminal Court
- B ✓ Chancery Court**
- C Circuit Court
- D The U.S. District Court

Answer: B. DOK 2: Chancery courts are Tennessee's courts of equity — handling matters such as contracts, property disputes, and injunctions — and are led by a Chancellor. Circuit courts hear

HOOK

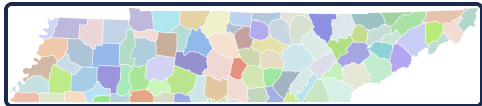
One building in Nashville houses lawmakers who meet only part of the

★ **TENNESSEE** This entire standard is Tennessee. The three stars on the state flag stand for the three Grand Divisions — East, Middle, and West — and Tennessee law spreads offices and representation across all three. The state's part-time citizen-legislature and its distinctive 'Tennessee Plan' for choosing appellate judges are features of Tennessee's own constitution and law (GC.28).

Local Government in Tennessee

Learning target: I can explain the differences among county, city, and metropolitan governments in Tennessee and how they relate legally, fiscally, and operationally to the state.

PRIMARY SOURCE



Tennessee's ninety-five counties — the county layer of local government that covers every part of the state. Find your own county on the map.

“The qualified voters of each county shall elect for terms of four years a legislative body, a county executive, a Sheriff, a Trustee, a Register, a County Clerk and an Assessor of Property.” — Constitution of Tennessee, Tennessee Constitution, Article VII, Section 1 (1978)

Tennessee County Map (all 95 counties) · U.S. Census Bureau (derivative) (n.d.) · Wikimedia Commons

HOOK

You live in a county. You might also live in a city. Both collect taxes, run

KEY VOCABULARY

Unitary Government /YOO-nih-tair-ee/
gobierno unitario

A system in which a central government — here, the state — holds the primary authority and creates the local governments beneath it, which exercise only the powers the state grants. Tennessee is a unitary state.

CHECK FOR UNDERSTANDING · DOK 2

Tennessee is a unitary state. What does that mean for your county and city governments?

- A They are completely independent of the state
- B They report directly to the federal government
- C ✓ They are created by the state and hold only the powers the state grants them
- D They may set aside state law within their own borders

Answer: C. DOK 2: In a unitary system, local governments are 'creatures of the state.' Under Dillon's Rule, Tennessee's counties and cities derive their authority from the state and have no powers not granted by the state.

Identify Your Current Officials

Learning target: I can identify the current governor of Tennessee and the state legislators who represent me, using official sources.

PRIMARY SOURCE



The Tennessee state flag: its three stars stand for the three Grand Divisions — East, Middle, and West.

“The Supreme Executive power of this State shall be vested in a Governor.” — Constitution of Tennessee, Tennessee Constitution, Article III, Section 1 (1870)

Flag of Tennessee · State of Tennessee (design 1905) (1905) · Wikimedia Commons

HOOK

Right now, a governor in Nashville and two legislators — one senator, one representative — make decisions for the exact spot where you live. Do you know their names? By the end of this lesson, you will have looked them up yourself.

KEY VOCABULARY

Governor /GUV-ur-ner/

gobernador(a)

Tennessee's chief executive, elected statewide to a four-year term, who carries out state law, proposes the state budget, and sets policy priorities. Identify the current officeholder from an

CHECK FOR UNDERSTANDING · DOK 1

To find out who currently represents you in the Tennessee General Assembly, the best source is —

- A ✓** the official 'Find My Legislator' tool on the Tennessee General Assembly site (capitol.tn.gov)
- B** a rumor you saw on social media
- C** a textbook printed several years ago
- D** a friend's best guess

Answer: A. DOK 1: Officeholders change with each election, so the accurate way to identify your current senator and representative is the official 'Find My Legislator' address-lookup

Whose Government? Perspectives on Power in Tennessee

Separation of Powers, State Level

Tennessee splits authority into three departments — legislative, executive, and judicial — the same design as the national government, applied to the state (GC.28).

Balancing the Grand Divisions

East, Middle, and West Tennessee each carry distinct histories and interests; the state deliberately balances offices and representation across all three (GC.28).

A Unitary State, Layered Locally

Authority flows from the state down to counties, cities, and consolidated metropolitan governments — each one created by, and answerable to, the state (GC.29).

Representation and Civic Action

Government reaches all the way down to your own district and your own officials — and this unit asks you to identify them, contact them, and take part (GC.30).

Our Signature Move



This whole unit is the Tennessee Connection. Foundations traced government in the abstract; here it becomes concrete and local — the Capitol in Nashville, the three Grand Divisions marked by the three stars on the state flag, the ninety-five counties on the state map, and the specific legislators elected from your own district. Tennessee is not an example in this unit; Tennessee is the subject (GC.28–GC.30).

Predict • Play • Spiral

Predict First — open the unit

Predict first: Which level of government — your city, your county, or the state — do you think has the biggest effect on your daily life? Write your gut answer now; you'll test it against how Tennessee actually divides and shares power.

Warm-Up Play — Who Governs? / Which Court?

4-minute game (GC.28–GC.29). Read a one-line scenario — a felony trial, a property-line dispute, a new city zoning rule, a statewide budget — and call which trial court (Circuit, Chancery, or Criminal) or which level of government (city, county, or state) handles it. Students feel how Tennessee's three branches and its layers of local government split the work.

Spiral — retrieve & connect

GC.28 → Unit 1 (Foundations — separation of powers)

Tennessee's three departments mirror the federal separation of powers you met in Foundations — same design, applied at the state level.

GC.29 → Unit 1/2 (federalism)

Federalism divides power between the nation and the states; this unit goes one layer deeper — how a state shares power with its counties and cities.

GC.30 → Unit 3 (GC.14, your members of Congress)

In Unit 3 you identified your U.S. senators and representative; now identify who represents you in Nashville — your state senator and state representative.

Local Government Forum

- Name the level (city / county / state) and the branch before you argue.
- Use your own county or district as a real, concrete example.
- Separate 'how it works now' from 'what you would change.'
- One voice at a time; make room for the quiet voice.

Revisit the Essential Question

“How does Tennessee govern itself at the state and local levels — and how do you take part?”

Students now have the sources, vocabulary, and reasoning to answer it — in a CER paragraph or the unit DBQ.

GC.28 · GC.29 · GC.30